

Tacere: Disclosure as a Governance Decision in Professional Environments

Akilah E. Kamaria | Lozen Advisory LLC

Abstract

Existing workplace frameworks addressing disclosure, accommodation, and retention assume that non-disclosure reflects a gap in psychological safety, legal literacy, or organizational support. This paper argues that assumption is structurally incomplete.

It introduces Tacere: the sustained, strategic practice of keeping one's own counsel by a senior executive operating in a professional environment where disclosure carries professional risk. Tacere is not a failure condition. It is a governance decision made in response to an incentive structure in which visibility carries cost and concealment remains an option.

The paper distinguishes Tacere from adjacent constructs including impression management, identity concealment, covering, coping, and strategic ambiguity. Unlike these frameworks, Tacere operates prior to and independently of any organizational relationship. It does not require an audience, a stigmatized identity, or a distress condition. It requires only the individual's assessment of professional risk.

The paper demonstrates that professional environments produce Tacere through the interaction of incentive and opportunity structures, without requiring organizational intent. It further argues that for Black and African American women, the cost structure of visibility is historically compounded, making race a foundational condition of the decision environment rather than a moderating variable.

The framework has implications for organizational governance, retention risk, and workplace policy design. Systems that require disclosure to activate systematically exclude the population most affected by it. The paper introduces Disclosure-Independent Performance Protection(SM) as a conceptual design constraint for support architectures that must function in the presence of Tacere rather than in opposition to it.

I.

Introduction

Workplace frameworks addressing disclosure, accommodation, and retention share a foundational assumption: that the decision to not disclose a health condition, a caregiving obligation, or a limitation on her availability reflects a gap in organizational conditions. The dominant explanations are familiar. Psychological safety is insufficient. Legal pathways are unclear. Support infrastructure is inadequate or inaccessible. Logic says: improve the conditions, and disclosure will follow.

This paper argues that assumption is structurally incomplete.

The individual who assessed organizational conditions accurately, weighed the professional cost of transparency against the cost of concealment, and decided that disclosure is not rational in her current environment is not experiencing a gap in psychological safety. She is exercising a governance function. She is making a calculated determination about information asymmetry, in a professional environment where the incentive structure makes transparency costly and concealment viable.

That determination may persist across years, across roles, and across organizations. It may operate entirely in the absence of distress. It may coexist with full professional performance, strong performance reviews, and organizational recognition as a top performer. None of those conditions change the calculation. They may reinforce it.

Tacere is defined as the sustained, strategic practice of keeping one's own counsel by a senior executive operating in a professional environment where disclosure carries professional risk. It is not a failure condition. It is a governance decision.

The framework classifies Tacere as a distinct subject of study within organizational behavior, labor economics, and employment law, and argues that its absence from the existing literature constitutes a structural gap with material consequences for organizational governance, retention risk, and workplace policy design.

This paper is the individual behavioral complement to a companion conceptual framework, Invisible Attrition(SM): A Conceptual Framework for Leadership Capacity Erosion Prior to Organizational Detection, which addresses the organizational measurement consequences of the same structural condition. Together the two frameworks propose that Tacere and Invisible Attrition(SM) are two observations of the same incentive structure from two different positions: the individual who has decided not to disclose her condition, and the organization that has no instrument to detect the retention risk that her decision is creating.

II.

Disclosure as Foundational Assumption: A Review of Three Literatures

These frameworks share a foundational assumption that disclosure is what activates support, protection, and intervention. The woman who has not disclosed is not a failure of the framework. She is simply outside it. The framework was never designed to reach her, and the data it generates will never reflect her presence because the collection condition requires an act she has not taken.

Accommodation and Employment Law Frameworks

The Americans with Disabilities Act, state-level workplace protection statutes, and the expanding body of menopause, chronic illness, and caregiver status legislation that has emerged across more than twenty states since 2024 all require disclosure as the initiating condition for protection. The support activates when the record exists. Without the record, the system has nothing to act on.

What the accommodation and employment law literature does not address is the individual who has assessed the available protections, understood the statutory landscape, and determined that disclosure remains professionally untenable regardless of what the law permits. The barrier literature treats non-disclosure as a response to insufficient conditions. It does not classify the sustained strategic practice that operates when the individual has assessed the conditions and found them insufficient, not through ignorance of what is available, but through accurate assessment of what disclosure would cost her in the specific professional environment she navigates.

Psychological Safety Research

The psychological safety literature, developed most influentially through Edmondson's (1999) foundational work, treats non-disclosure as evidence of insufficient psychological safety within an organizational context. The prescription is organizational: improve the conditions, train the managers, signal from leadership that disclosure is safe.

Its limitation for the purposes of this paper is structural rather than methodological. The psychological safety framework treats the organizational environment as the independent variable and individual disclosure behavior as the dependent variable. It does not account for the individual who has accurately assessed the organizational environment, concluded that the environment is safe enough in general, but not safe enough for this specific disclosure. That executive is not experiencing low psychological safety in the sense the literature measures. She is making a governance decision the framework was not designed to capture.

Retention and Attrition Research

The retention and attrition literature classifies voluntary departure as the terminal event and works backward from exit data to identify predictive indicators. Engagement surveys, performance trajectories, manager relationship quality, and compensation competitiveness are the dominant instruments. This framework cannot detect what was never created. When a senior professional departs following years of sustained high performance, without prior accommodation requests and without any disclosed condition, the departure registers as voluntary.

The departure arrives without warning, because the warning was the signal she decided not to give.

Across all three bodies of literature, the sustained strategic practice of keeping one's own counsel in a professional environment where disclosure carries professional risk is treated as the unexplained residue. The contribution of this paper is to name it as a subject of study in its own right.

III.

Tacere: Definition, Behavioral Mechanics, and Distinguishing the Framework

Tacere is defined as the sustained, strategic practice of keeping one's own counsel by a senior executive operating in a professional environment where disclosure carries professional risk. The term draws from the Latin tacere, to be silent, to withhold, to leave unmentioned. The Latin carries a precise implication that the English word silent does not: tacere is not the silence in the absence of analysis. It is the silence of decision. The individual practicing Tacere has something to say. She has decided not to say it.

The definition has three analytically necessary components.

Sustained	Tacere is not a single decision but a practice maintained over time, often across years, requiring continuous recalibration as the professional environment shifts. The practice is active rather than passive, requiring ongoing attention to the incentive structure and ongoing management of the gap between what she is carrying and what the organization sees.
Strategic	The practice is calculated, not reactive. It reflects an ongoing assessment of the incentive structure and the professional cost of transparency at each decision point. The same individual may practice Tacere in one professional environment and choose disclosure in another. The condition being managed did not change; the incentive structure did.

The individual practicing Tacere is not withholding from the organization. She is governing her own information in an environment she has assessed as unable to receive it safely. The sovereignty belongs to her. She is neither lying, nor hiding. She is exercising a governance function over her own information in an environment where the cost structure makes that exercise rational and necessary.

Distinguishing Tacere from Adjacent Constructs

Five constructs in the existing literature are close enough to Tacere to require a clear distinction. Each shares common ground but breaks from the framework on salient dimensions.

Impression management (Goffman, 1959) is relational and audience-dependent. Tacere operates prior to that space. It does not require an audience. The organization is never a party to the calculation.

Identity concealment describes the active hiding of a stigmatized identity. Tacere does not require a stigmatized identity. It requires a professional environment where disclosure carries professional cost. The mechanism is professional risk, not stigma. Goffman's framework governs social acceptance. Tacere governs professional viability.

Covering (Yoshino, 2006) describes the downplaying of a known identity within an organizational relationship that already exists. Tacere operates before the identity is known to anyone in the professional context.

Coping is a reactive, distress-dependent response. Tacere may operate entirely in the absence of distress. The individual making a governance decision about information asymmetry is not managing distress. She is managing risk.

Strategic ambiguity describes the deliberate use of language within an organizational relationship. Tacere operates prior to any organizational communication. The individual practicing Tacere is not communicating ambiguously about her condition. She is not communicating about it at all.

The correct classification is governance. Tacere is a governance decision about information asymmetry in a professional environment where the incentive structure makes transparency costly and concealment rational.

The professional environment does not produce Tacere by accident, by failure, or by design flaw. It produces Tacere because it contains two structural conditions sufficient to make sustained non-disclosure the rational choice: an incentive structure that makes disclosure costly, and an opportunity structure that makes concealment viable. Neither condition requires organizational intent. Neither requires malice.

An organization can invest genuinely and substantially in wellness infrastructure, accommodation pathways, and psychological safety programming and still produce Tacere as a predictable outcome, because the incentive and opportunity structure operates beneath those investments.

Systems do not require intent. They require incentive and opportunity.

Visibility Is Not a Neutral State

Visibility is not a condition that organizational improvements either produce or suppress. It is a state that carries professional cost in both directions, and those costs are not symmetrical. Disclosing a health condition produces visibility of a specific kind: one in which the executive is now seen as someone whose authority may be in question. That perception alters how authority is read, how career trajectory is assessed, and how the individual is positioned in the informal systems that govern promotion, assignment, and organizational standing.

Concealment carries cost as well, though accumulated rather than immediate. The individual who does not disclose absorbs the cost of managing her condition without organizational support, without clinical engagement that might produce a record, and without adjustment to the demands placed on her. The cost accumulates without generating the record that it is accumulating. From the outside the record shows sustained performance. From the inside the conditions sustaining that performance are eroding.

The Power User Trap(SM)

The opportunity structure that makes Tacere viable is not random. It is created and sustained by her own performance record. The stronger her output, the less the organization is designed to question whether she needs support. The more consistently she delivers, the more the system reads her performance as evidence that nothing is wrong.

The Power User Trap(SM) describes this dynamic: the executive whose output registers as evidence that no support is needed is the executive for whom the existing protection architecture is least accessible. The performance record that makes her indispensable also makes her invisible to the protective instruments calibrated to detect declining performance as the signal for intervention.

The Power User Group(SM) does not require that the organization intend to exclude its talent from protection. It requires only that the protection architecture be calibrated to the signal of need that senior executives are least likely to generate.

V.

The Intersectional Dimension

The existing literature on workplace disclosure treats race as a moderating variable: a factor that influences the degree or frequency of an already-described behavior. This paper argues that framing is analytically insufficient for this framework. For Black and African American women in professional environments, race is not a moderating variable that adjusts the degree of Tacere. It is a foundational condition of the calculation itself.

For Black women, becoming visible as someone whose authority may be in question does not produce the same outcome as it does for other populations. Research confirms that Black women in leadership are held to different and higher standards, often lack the support white peers have access to, and are frequently centered in leadership during periods of crisis while being denied full institutional support. The excess mental and emotional labor this produces represents a compounded cost structure that other populations do not carry (Ely and Mayo, 2024).

The Strong Black Woman Construct as Survival Architecture

The strong Black woman construct is not a personality trait or a psychological pattern. It is a survival architecture, externally imposed and internally maintained, predating the professional relationship and operating inside it. It is the behavioral and cognitive infrastructure developed in response to a structural environment that has historically made vulnerability costly and self-sufficiency necessary.

The strong Black woman construct compounds the cost of disclosure in a specific and analytically important way: it does not merely add an additional barrier. It makes the practice of Tacere structurally reinforced from two directions simultaneously. The professional environment provides the incentive and opportunity conditions that produce Tacere for the general population. The survival architecture compounds the individual cost of departing from the practice even when the professional environment signals that departure might be safe. Their interaction is what makes the intersectional dimension of this framework foundational rather than additive.

The argument is not that Black women experience Tacere differently in degree. It is that the structural conditions that produce Tacere operate differently for Black women in kind.

VI.

Disclosure-Independent Performance Protection(SM) is introduced here as a conceptual category describing a structural response architecture with a different foundational requirement. It does not require disclosure as an initiating condition. It does not activate in response to a disclosed need. It does not generate a record within any organizational system that carries professional risk for the individual it serves. It is built to operate in the presence of Tacere rather than in opposition to it.

Foundational Design Principles

A structural response architecture designed to function in the presence of Tacere must satisfy two foundational conditions that existing support frameworks do not.

Disclosure Independence	The framework must produce value without requiring the individual to name her condition, disclose her need, or generate any record that enters an organizational system she did not choose. This is not a privacy feature appended to an existing support model. It is a foundational architectural requirement. Any framework that requires disclosure to function will fail the population for whom disclosure carries the highest cost.
Asset Orientation	The framework treats the individual's professional role, compensation trajectory, authority, and standing as assets worth defending rather than as organizational outputs to be managed. Disclosure-Independent Performance Protection(SM) is designed around the individual's interest in protecting her influence and her position within systems she is actively shaping but does not yet fully command.

Disclosure-Independent Performance Protection(SM) is not a correction to Tacere. It is not designed to reduce the incidence of Tacere, encourage disclosure, or produce a different individual decision. It is designed to operate in the presence of the decision the individual has already made. The framework accepts the governance decision as given.

Tacere is not the absence of analysis. It is the product of it. A response architecture built for that individual must begin from the premise that her decision is rational, that the environment that produced it has not changed, and that support which requires her to revise that decision before it activates is not, in any functionally meaningful sense, available to her.

Implications

Organizational Governance

Leadership capacity erodes, performance continuity degrades, and when departure eventually comes it is recorded as voluntary and personal. The organization loses assets it did not know it was at risk of losing because the risk never generated a signal within any system responsible for detecting it.

The Power User Trap(SM) is the mechanism by which that gap becomes a governance exposure: the executive whose performance record signals stability is the executive whose departure the organization will not have predicted and cannot explain. Naming this risk as such is the first requirement for managing it.

Retention Risk

Standard retention and attrition instruments do not function for the senior executive whose departure is preceded by none of the standard behavioral signals, because the practice of Tacere has kept the conditions producing the departure invisible to the systems responsible for detecting risk. The exit data will show full performance until departure. The retention instrument will not flag the departure as anomalous because the performance record provided no prior signal of risk.

The implication is not a better measurement instrument. The implication is architectural. The response infrastructure must be built to function without her data, without her signal, and without her disclosure. The gap in the record is not the problem to solve. It is the condition to design around.

Workplace Policy Design

The legislative and policy response to menopause, chronic illness, and caregiver status has accelerated significantly across state and federal jurisdictions since 2024. The policy design in every jurisdiction examined shares the foundational architecture this paper has documented: protection activates when disclosure occurs.

The population most affected is disproportionately concentrated in the population for whom disclosure carries the highest professional cost. The legislation being enacted reaches the women who can afford to invoke it. The women most likely to need these protections are the least likely to invoke them.

Michigan Menopause Memorandum (2025)	Fewer than 1 in 5 women disclosed their menopause status at work. 30% were not comfortable discussing symptoms. 52% reported workplace culture did not support taking time off for menopause-related symptoms. Only 8% expressed satisfaction with available resources.
Korn Ferry / Vira Health (8,000+ women)	Only 42% had spoken with their line manager about their experiences. Only 37% had spoken with HR. Only 27% had spoken with senior leadership. Senior executives reported menopause symptoms had more than twice the effect on promotions compared to individual contributors.
LiveCareer (2025)	97% of employed women reported feeling pressured to hide or downplay symptoms at work. 91% begin experiencing symptoms before age 50, the same period many step into senior management and leadership roles.

These data sources confirm the paper's central thesis: the population this framework describes does not fail to engage with available support because it lacks access, information, or legal protection. It has assessed those conditions and made a different decision. Policy design that does not account for that decision will continue to measure and serve only the population that discloses.

VIII.

Limitations

This paper is conceptual and advances a classification framework rather than an empirical test of the phenomena it describes. The claims advanced here are structural and analytical, not statistical, and do not assert that all instances of non-disclosure reflect the practice defined as Tacere.

The framework is intentionally bounded to a specific population: senior executives operating in professional environments where the cost of visibility carries organizational and career consequences and concealment is viable. Tacere is not directly measurable at the individual level without violating its defining constraint, which is the absence of disclosure and the non-generation of a record. The framework is structurally inferable rather than individually observable, and future empirical work should be designed accordingly.

IX.

Conclusion

This paper has introduced Tacere as a conceptual framework naming a condition that existing organizational behavior, labor economics, and employment law literatures have not classified as a subject of study in its own right. The sustained, strategic practice of keeping one's own counsel by a senior executive operating in a professional environment where disclosure carries professional risk is not a failure condition. It is a governance decision produced by a structural incentive and opportunity system that makes transparency costly and concealment rational.

The contribution of this paper is classification. The condition has been present in the professional lives of women, particularly Black and African American women in professional environments, long before this paper named it. Naming it is the first requirement for addressing it.

Tacere is not the absence of analysis. It is the product of it. Invisible Attrition(SM) addresses what the organization cannot see. Tacere addresses why the individual decided not to disclose. Together they propose that the structural condition is legible, nameable, and addressable. Classification is the precondition for infrastructure design. Infrastructure design is the precondition for reach. She was never silent. She decided.

References

- Album, D., and S. Westin. 2008. "Do Diseases Have a Prestige Hierarchy?" *Social Science and Medicine* 66 (1): 182-188.
- Bonafide Health. 2024. "State of Menopause 2024." Annual Survey of 2,013 U.S. Women.
- Edmondson, A.C. 1999. "Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams." *Administrative Science Quarterly* 44 (2): 350-383.
- Ely, R.J., and A. Mayo. 2024. "Black Women in Leadership." Harvard Business School Race, Gender and Equity Initiative.
- Escalera, J. 2025. "The Silent Struggle." LiveCareer Working Through Menopause Report.
- Giddings, P.J. 1984. *When and Where I Enter*. New York: William Morrow.
- Goffman, E. 1959. *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*. New York: Doubleday Anchor.
- Goffman, E. 1963. *Stigma: Notes on the Management of Spoiled Identity*. Prentice-Hall.
- Kamaria, A.E. 2025. "Invisible Attrition(SM): A Conceptual Framework for Leadership Capacity Erosion Prior to Organizational Detection." SSRN Working Paper. ssrn.com/abstract=6397780
- Korn Ferry Institute and Vira Health. 2023. "Understanding the Role of Menopause in Work and Careers." Global Survey of 8,000+ Women.
- Maven Clinic. 2024. "Millenopause at Work." Survey of 1,050 Millennials and Gen X Women.
- Michigan Women's Commission. 2025. *Michigan Menopause Memorandum*. State of Michigan.
- Norredam, M., and D. Album. 2007. "Prestige and Its Significance for Medical Specialties and Diseases." *Scandinavian Journal of Public Health* 35 (6): 655-661.

Tacere, Power User Trap(SM), Invisible Attrition(SM), and Disclosure-Independent Performance Protection(SM) are service marks of Lozen Advisory LLC. All rights reserved. This paper is for informational and educational purposes only. Copyright 2025 Lozen Advisory LLC.